

13: AWAY FROM THE WALLS

壁の外へ

THE TRIAD. THE DISRUPTOR. THE WEB.
THE JOURNEY BEGINS.

EPISODE 13

DISPLACEMENT.
VELOCITY.
CONSEQUENCE.



KAGEYURU
[影混る]

ASTRID BRANDT

アストリッド・ブランド

THE WEAVER. THE CATALYST.
SHE DOESN'T FOLLOW THE SYSTEM.
SHE REWRITES IT.



KAGEYURU // 影混る
VOLUME 01: TRANSCENDENCE

旅は、静かに世界を変える。

THE QUIETEST JOURNEYS
CHANGE EVERYTHING.

DAWN.
HERITAGE STUDY TRIP.
FORTY-TWO STUDENTS.
ONE ASSIGNED ORDER.

ATTENTION, PLEASE.
THE HIKARI 503
TO KYOTO IS NOW
BOARDING.

ALPHABETICAL BY
HOMEROOM.
WEEKS AGO.
NO ONE THOUGHT
TO CHECK.
NO ONE COULD
HAVE KNOWN.

#1111

11号車
Car No. 11

KAI MORI
17
THE READER
OF TRUTH

FOUR ROWS
BEFORE HER.
SIX ROWS
BEFORE HIM.
NOT BY CHOICE.
BY ORDER.
BY SYSTEM.
BY NOTHING
AT ALL.

HIKARI 503
CAR 11
SEAT 11D
森海
5:03発→京都行き

11C	MATSUMOTO, R.
11D	MORI, KAI
11E	NAKAMURA, Y.
11F	NARITA, S.
12A	OGAWA, T.
12B	SAITO, M.
12C	SHIBATA, H.
12D	SUGAWARA, K.
12E	TAKAHASHI, Y.
12F	TENDO, REIKA
13A	TOKUDA, A.
13B	NAKANO, I.
16C	MINABE, SORA
16D	MIYAMOTO, K.
16E	YAMAGUCHI, D.
16F	YOSHIDA, R.
...	

REIKA TENDO
18
THE READER
OF THE PAST

FOUR ROWS
AWAY.
NOT FAR.
NOT CLOSE.
JUST OUT OF REACH.

HIKARI 503 6:08 Kyoto
This train stops at: Shin-Yokohama, Nagoya, Kyoto
KODAMA 645 6:12 Kyoto
This train stops at: All stations

SINCE
THE NODE,
WE'VE
ALWAYS BEEN
TOGETHER.
ALWAYS.
UNTIL NOW.

SIX ROWS
AWAY.
WATCHING.
NOTHING
HE CAN DO.
NOWHERE
TO STAND
BETWEEN IT.

SORA MINABE
16
THE READER
OF THE FUTURE

TOKYO TO KYOTO.
CLASS 2-A SCHOOL TRIP.

THE TRAIN
PULLS OUT.

THE
PERFORMANCE
BEGINS.

さあ、みんなで歌おう！
行こうぜ！京都～！

LET'S ALL
SING TOGETHER!
KYOTO~!

FORCED
COLLECTIVE
CHEER.

A HARMONIZED
PERFORMANCE
OF JOY.

TO ME,
IT'S JUST
ANOTHER
LAYER OF
TRUTH.

YEAHHH!

WOOO!

行こうぜ！
京都～！

LET'S
GOOO!

THE TEACHER
LEADS.

THE STUDENTS
RESPOND.

THE SONG
CONTINUES.

THE TRUTH
REMAINS.

PRESENT TRUTH: CLASS 2-A / CAR 5

BOREDOM
92%

HOMESICKNESS
87%

GENUINE
EXCITEMENT
95%

SOCIAL ANXIETY
78%

PERFORMING
ENTHUSIASM
65%

JUST HERE FOR
THE FOOD
85%

CABIN ASSIGNMENT
STRESS
91%

TRYING TO FIT IN
68%

DISGUISED
RELUCTANCE
73%

SLEEP
DEPRIVATION
89%

THE COST
OF SIGHT
FADES.

THE HUM
REMAINS.

FAMILIAR.

I CAN JOIN
THE SONG.

BUT I CAN'T
UNREAD
THE TRUTH.

行こうぜ！
京都～！

SO I WATCH.
I LISTEN.

I REMAIN
OUTSIDE
THE
PERFORMANCE.

REIKA TENDO

18

THE READER
OF THE PAST



STUDENT
COUNCIL
PRESIDENT

過去の読者
天童 靈歌

1



THE LANDSCAPE
SHIFTS.
CITY EASES.
TIME THICKENS.

2



HER VISION
SOFTENS.
NOT DARKNESS.
WEIGHT.
LAYER UPON
LAYER.
CENTURIES
PRESSED
AGAINST
THE GLASS.

3



COLOR
DRAINS
AT THE EDGES.
THE PAST
DOES NOT
ARRIVE—
IT SEEPS.
BEHIND GREEN,
THE ASH
OF AGES.

4



THE STRAIN
FINDS HER.
NOT LOUD.
NOT VISIBLE.
NEW.
UNMANAGEABLE.
AT SPEED.
AT SCALE.
SHE DOES
NOT SPEAK.
NO ONE WOULD
UNDERSTAND.



KAI MORI, 17.
NOTICES.

THREE ROWS
AHEAD.

A GIRL
WHO DOES NOT
BELONG TO THE
TRIP'S SOCIAL
FABRIC.

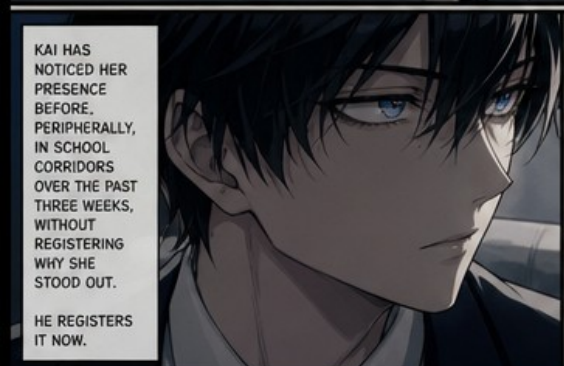


ASTRID BRANDT, 17.
GERMAN EXCHANGE STUDENT.
FROM BERLIN.
THE READER OF THE WEB.

SHE IS NOT SINGING
THE TRIP SONG.

SHE IS NOT
ON HER PHONE.

SHE SITS
PERFECTLY STILL,
GAZING SLIGHTLY
PAST THE SEAT
IN FRONT OF HER
WITH THE SPECIFIC,
UNFOCUSED
ATTENTION OF
SOMEONE READING
SOMETHING
NOBODY ELSE
IN THE CARRIAGE
CAN SEE.



KAI HAS
NOTICED HER
PRESENCE
BEFORE.
PERIPHERALLY,
IN SCHOOL
CORRIDORS
OVER THE PAST
THREE WEEKS,
WITHOUT
REGISTERING
WHY SHE
STOOD OUT.

HE REGISTERS
IT NOW.



HIS GAZE
HELD
UNNATURALLY
LONG ACROSS
THREE ROWS
OF FORCED
CHEERFULNESS.



HER RED
PRESENCE
BURNS THROUGH
THE CARRIAGE'S
PERFORMED
MONOTONY
LIKE A WOUND
REFUSING
TO BLEND.



THE INSTANT OF
MUTUAL NOTICE.
KAI'S COLD ANALYTICAL
RECOGNITION MEETS
ASTRID'S COMPLETE
INDIFFERENCE TO
OBSERVATION.



SOMETHING
UNNAMEABLE
REGISTERS BETWEEN
THEM.

KAI MORI. 17.
THE READER OF TRUTH.

I READ THE PRESENT.
EVERYONE'S PRESENT.
GUILT. INTENT.
MOTIVE. LIE.

UNTIL TODAY,
I THOUGHT I WAS
THE ONLY ONE
WHO COULD SEE.

ASTRID BRANDT. 17.
THE READER OF THE WEB.

SHE DOESN'T READ
THE PRESENT.

SHE READS
CONNECTION.

I TRY TO READ HER
THE WAY I READ
EVERYONE.

THE GRID FORMS.
THE LINES LOCK.

BUT NOT WITH HER.
THE GRID SLIDES.
REFUSES TO SETTLE.

IT BENDS AROUND HER
LIKE LIGHT AROUND
SOMETHING...DENSE.

AND BENEATH IT—
SOMETHING ELSE.
SOMETHING I DON'T
UNDERSTAND.

ROW 12.
OLD MAN.
PAID OFF DEBT.

ROW 3.
KID.
SHE SAVED HIM
LAST MONTH.

ROW 27.
COUPLE.
FAKE DATING.
REAL DEAL.

THREADS.
NOT OF LIES.
NOT OF GUILT.

THREADS OF
COMPLICITY.
OF CHOICE.
OF CONNECTION.

A MAP THAT HAS
NOTHING TO DO
WITH THE PRESENT...

...AND
EVERYTHING
TO DO WITH
EVERYTHING
ELSE.

I CAN'T
PARSE IT.

CAN'T
READ IT.

CAN'T
CONTROL IT.

SHE SEES
SOMETHING
I DON'T.

OR WORSE—
SHE SEES
MORE.

I AM NOT
ALONE.

AND WHAT
I SEE...

IS NOT ALL
THERE IS.

FOR THE FIRST TIME
IN A YEAR...

...MY SIGHT
IS NOT ENOUGH.

AND THAT...

...IS MORE TERRIFYING
THAN ANY LIE.

LATER
THAT DAY.

SCHOOL TRIP:
TRAIN TO BUS.

KZZZT

...and on our
left, you'll see
Lake Kawaguchi...

KZZZT

...bluh blah blah
historical significance
blah blah...

KZZZT

Everything
curves.

All of it.

No center.
No north.

No reading
points.

My head
won't stop
swimming.

Not from
the bus.

From
nothing
to hold
onto.

...

At school,
I can bend
toward
something
I know.

A wall,
A hallway.
A person.

Here?

...
Every
direction
useless.

First time
in months
I don't
know what
to write.

No direction
to record.

Just...
this.

A gift
without
an anchor
is just
a storm.

I want
to help.

I want
to make
sense of
it.

But I can't
even make
sense of
where I am.
...

BEING THE
QUIET OBSERVER
ONLY WORKS
WHEN THERE'S
SOMETHING
TO OBSERVE.

OUT HERE,
I'M JUST...
NOISE IN
MOTION.

The Landscape Remembers

Unplanned

— Chapter 17 —

SORA MINABE

16

Small.
Unremarkable.

REIKA TENDO

18

Manages the
landscape's
ambient flooding.
Since the train.

Her knuckles
still pale on
the armrest.

Her gaze fixed
and slightly
too still on
the window.

He notices.
He understands
without knowing
what it is.

Not danger.
Not a threat.
Something
he cannot see
or aim at.

His consequence-dread,
useless for direction,
finds a new and
uncomfortable register:

He can feel, with
sickening clarity,
the specific future-
weight of watching
someone he has come
to trust absorb
something he cannot
see or aim at.

The simple
helpless
consequence
of proximity
to someone
else's private
cost.

He says
nothing.
He does
not know
how to help
with a flood
he cannot
perceive.

He simply
does not
move his
seat.



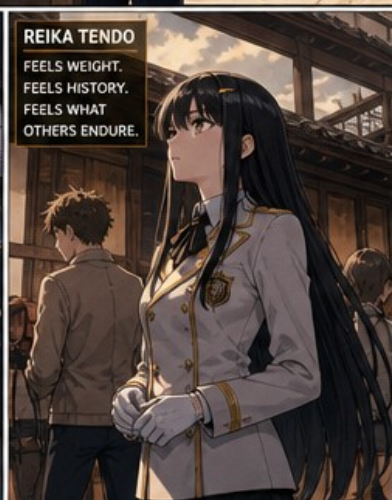
KAI MORI

SEES ORDER.
SEES STRUCTURE.
SEES WHAT
OTHERS MISS.



REIKA TENDO

FEELS WEIGHT.
FEELS HISTORY.
FEELS WHAT
OTHERS ENDURE.



SORA MINABE

FEELS OTHERS.
FEELS BURDEN.
FEELS WHAT
OTHERS CARRY.



ASTRID BRANDT

FEELS NOTHING.
FEARS NOTHING.
SEES THROUGH
EVERYTHING.



PLEASE
LEAVE YOUR
SHOES HERE.

SLIPPERS
THIS WAY.



EVERY BEAM.
EVERY JOIN.

EVERY LINE
SERVES A
PURPOSE.

THIS PLACE
IS PRECISE.

LIKE A CODE
OLDER THAN
MEMORY.



THE TIMBER
HOLDS
CENTURIES.

THE WALLS
HAVE
ABSORBED
COUNTLESS
STORIES.

THIS PLACE
EXPECTS
SOMETHING
OF ME.



SO MANY
VOICES.
SO MANY
WEIGHTS.

THIS PLACE
WILL TAKE
WHAT IT
NEEDS.

I NEED TO
BE READY.



OLD WOOD.
OLD GHOSTS.
OLD LIES.

I'VE SEEN
OLDER.

LET'S SEE
WHAT THIS
PLACE IS
MADE OF.





NOW, I'LL
READ OUT THE
ROOM ASSIGNMENTS.

THE ROOMS ARE
ASSIGNED BY
HOMEROOM CLASS.

PLEASE PROCEED
TO YOUR ROOMS
AND SETTLE IN.



CLASS 2-A
MORI KAI
ROOM 207
WITH
HOSHINO RYUSEI
AND
KATAOKA DAICHI.

...207.



CLASS 2-B
MINABE SORA
ROOM 203
WITH
MATSUKI REN
AND
IGARASHI TOMA.

...203.



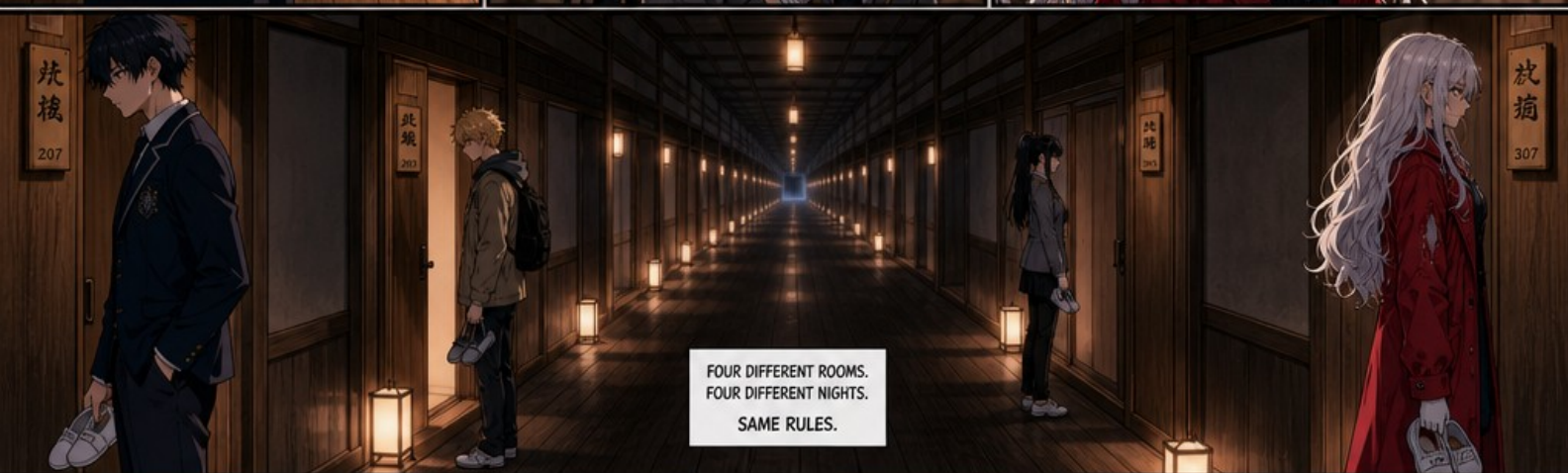
CLASS 2-A
TENDO REIKA
ROOM 305
WITH
FUJISAWA MAI
AND
SAIONJI YUKI.

...305.



CLASS 3-C
BRANDT ASTRID
ROOM 307
WITH
SHIRAKAWA LUNA
AND
KURAMOCHI MIKU.

...307.



FOUR DIFFERENT ROOMS.
FOUR DIFFERENT NIGHTS.
SAME RULES.



ANOTHER
POINTLESS
SEPARATION.

AS IF DISTANCE
COULD DULL
WHAT NEEDS
TO BE DONE.



I DON'T
MIND WHERE
I SLEEP.

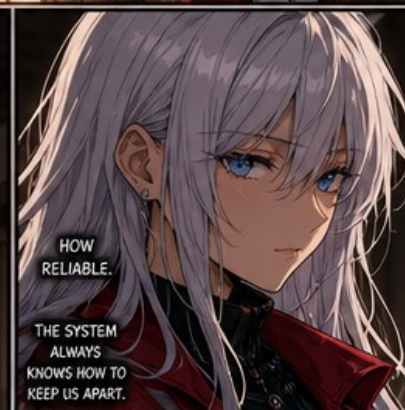
...BUT IT
WOULDN'T BEEN
NICE TO TALK
MORE WITH
THE OTHERS.



TWO DOORS
AWAY.

CLOSE ENOUGH
TO HEAR HER
FOOTSTEPS.

FAR ENOUGH
THAT SHE WON'T
ACKNOWLEDGE
MY EXISTENCE.



HOW
RELIABLE.

THE SYSTEM
ALWAYS
KNOWS HOW TO
KEEP US APART.

REIKA TENDO | 18

THE READER OF THE PAST

1

THE TOUCH.

BARELY
A BRUSH.
HALF A
SECOND.



THE CUFF
RIDES UP.

SKIN
TO OLD
WOOD.

THE PAST
ANSWERS.

2

THE PAST-FLASH.

THREE DAYS
EARLIER.

SAME WALL.
SAME POINT.

DIFFERENT
PRESENCE.



SILVERY HAIR.
RED COAT.
A SIMILAR GIFT.

DIFFERENT
SIGNATURE.

AMBER THREADS
INSTEAD OF
MONOCHROME.

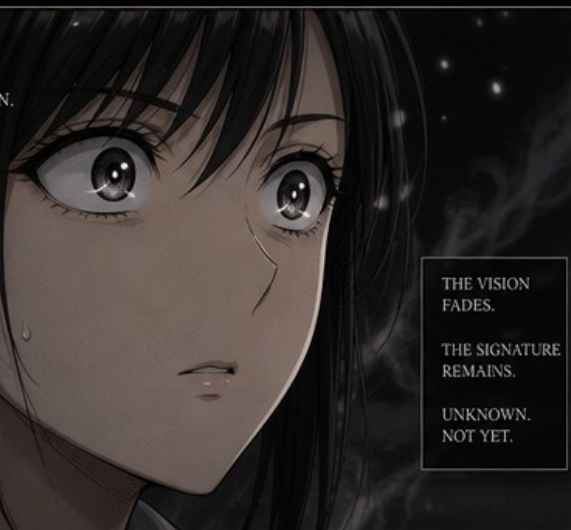
3

THE RECOGNITION.

NOT HISTORY.
NOT MEMORY.

SOMETHING
ELSE.

SOMEONE
LIKE HER.



THE VISION
FADES.

THE SIGNATURE
REMAINS.

UNKNOWN.
NOT YET.

4

THE COMPOSURE.

SLEEVE
DOWN.

MASK BACK
IN PLACE.

SHE LOOKS
FORWARD.

TOWARD A ROOM
THAT JUST REVEALED
ITSELF.



SOMEONE
WHO SEES.

SOMEONE
WHO READS.

SOMEONE
WHO CARRIES
A DIFFERENT
KIND OF
LONELINESS.

SOMEONE
WHO WAS HERE.
THREE DAYS
AGO.



It's here.
The cold point.

No source.
I know this.



I don't
test it.



For a beat—
porcelain.



Turn around.
Go back.



The gap
holds.



Tonight.

ANOTHER
PERFECTLY
ORCHESTRATED
EVENING.

ANOTHER
DATA POINT
IN THE GRAND
EXPERIMENT
OF HUMAN
CONNECTION.

TO NEW FRIENDSHIPS,
TO UNDERSTANDING,
AND TO THE BEAUTY
OF EXPERIENCING
ANOTHER CULTURE.

KANPAI!

KANPAI!

KANPAI!-

CHEERS!

THEY CALL
IT CULTURAL
EXCHANGE.

I CALL IT
OBSERVATION.

FOUR
PERCEIVERS.

FOUR DIFFERENT
TRUTHS.

FOUR SOLITUDES
IN PARALLEL.

INTELLIGENCE
ISOLATES.
IT'S THE CURSE
OF SEEING
PATTERNS
OTHERS CAN'T.

DUTY
ISOLATES.
IT'S THE
WEIGHT OF
EXPECTATIONS
NO ONE ELSE
CAN BEAR.

EMPATHY
ISOLATES.
IT'S THE BURDEN
OF FEELING
EVERYTHING
OTHERS TRY
TO IGNORE.

PERFECTION
ISOLATES.
IT'S THE
IMPOSSIBLE
STANDARD
THAT LEAVES
YOU ALONE.

THE WORLD
CELEBRATES
TOGETHERNESS.

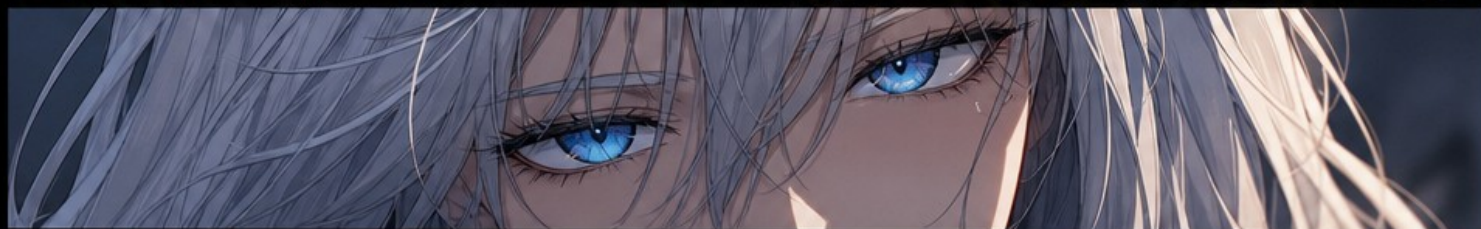
WE EXIST
IN THE
SPACES
BETWEEN.

ASTRID
BRANDT

Sees the
threads others
miss.

KAI
MORI

Reads the truth
behind what is
shown.



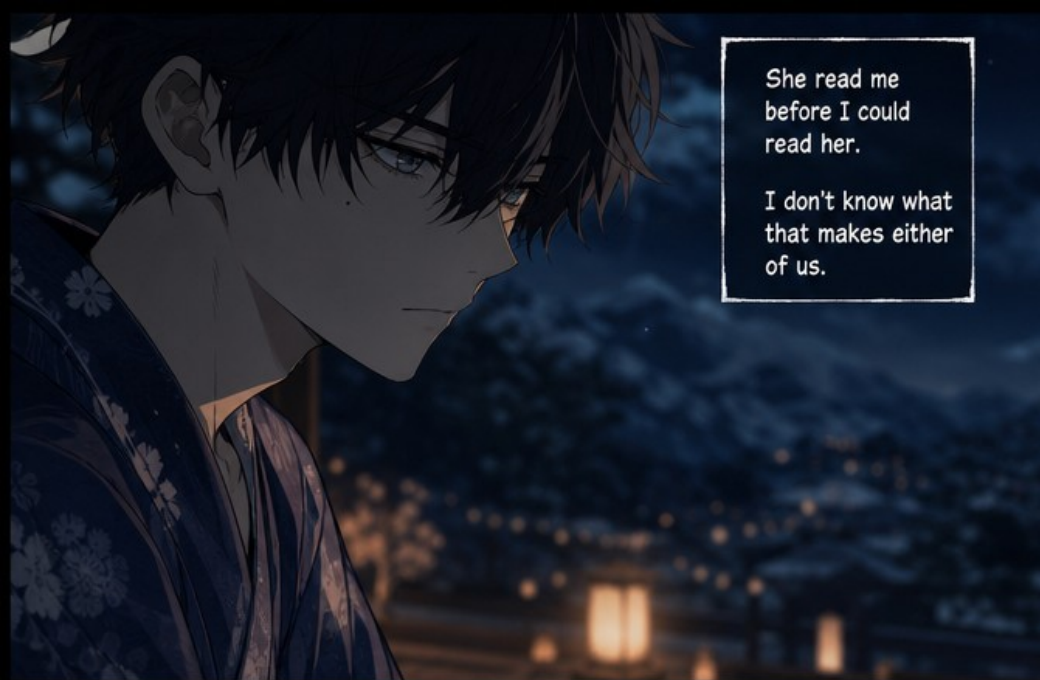
TWO SECONDS.

Then he looks
away.

Two perceivers.
Across a crowded room.
Recognizing what cannot be spoken.

His expression
gives nothing.
His room-mates
notice nothing
at all.

The raw connection between two minds
that see what others cannot.



She read me
before I could
read her.

I don't know what
that makes either
of us.



ANOTHER DAY
DROWNS IN SILENCE.

THE RYOKAN
RETURNS TO DARKNESS.

THE PLACES
REMEMBER.
EVEN WHEN THE
PEOPLE DO NOT.

THE WATCHERS
DO NOT SLEEP.

REIKA TENDO
ROOM 201

SHE FEELS
WHAT LIES
BENEATH.
EVEN IN
STILLNESS.

ASTRID BRANDT
ROOM 203

SHE SEEKS
WHAT OTHERS
FEAR TO
UNDERSTAND.
FEARLESS.

SORA MINABE
ROOM 205

HIE CARRIES
WHAT NONE
CAN BEAR.
THE FUTURES.

TWO DOORS DOWN
A SLIVER OF LIGHT

SHE KEEPS
WHAT MUST
NEVER BE
LOST.

AT THE REAR OF THE PROPERTY,
THE OLDEST STOREHOUSE REMAINS.
ITS WINDOWS DO NOT WAKE.

SOMETHING ANSWERS.
NOT TO THE MOON.
BUT TO THE PRESSURE THAT
BUILDS BENEATH THE WORLD.

TO BE CONTINUED.